

Skills Enhancement Lab: Cycle 1 Data Analysis
Post-Session Feedback From Master's-Level Counseling Students
in a Fully Online CACREP-Accredited Program

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Abstract

This report presents a descriptive and thematic analysis of post-session feedback data from Cycle 1 of an action research study evaluating the Skills Enhancement Lab (SEL), a synchronous, voluntary, non-evaluative skills coaching program for master's-level mental health counseling students in a fully online CACREP-accredited program. Sixty-eight anonymous post-session survey responses were collected between March 12 and March 21, 2026. Results indicated near-universal endorsement, with 98.5% of respondents ($n = 67$) selecting "Definitely go!" when asked what they would tell a reluctant peer. A voluntary open-ended question yielded a 91.2% response rate ($n = 62$). Inductive thematic analysis identified eight themes, with specific skill practice and feedback (69.4%), anxiety/nervousness reduction (33.9%), and hands-on practice-based learning (32.3%) as dominant themes. Nearly one in five respondents (19.4%) reported increased confidence and self-efficacy. The data represent a post-only satisfaction design with acknowledged limitations including the absence of pre-test measures, control groups, and direct skill outcome indicators. Findings are interpreted within the context of the online program modality and existing theoretical frameworks in counselor education. Recommendations for methodological enhancements in subsequent research cycles are provided.

Keywords: skills coaching, counselor education, action research, online learning, self-efficacy, formative feedback, thematic analysis

Skills Enhancement Lab: Cycle 1 Data Analysis

The Skills Enhancement Lab (SEL) is a synchronous, voluntary, non-evaluative skills coaching program designed for master's-level mental health counseling students in a fully online CACREP-accredited program. The SEL pairs students with trained doctoral-level coaches for individualized, live practice of counseling microskills (e.g., reflections of feeling, immediacy, confrontation, minimal encouragers) with real-time formative feedback. Because the program is fully online, students have virtually no other opportunity for live, synchronous, individualized skill practice with immediate expert feedback. The present report documents the analysis and interpretation of post-session feedback data collected during the first two weeks of SEL operations, constituting Cycle 1 of an ongoing action research investigation.

Method

Participants and Data Collection

Sixty-eight anonymous post-session survey responses were collected between March 12 and March 21, 2026, spanning two weeks of SEL operations across six collection days. All responses were anonymous; no identifying information was collected. The highest response volume occurred during the second week, with 61 of 68 responses (89.7%) submitted between March 19 and March 21.

Instrument

The post-session survey consisted of two items:

Question 1 (forced-choice): “Considering how you felt coming into the SEL today and how you feel now—what would you tell another student who was reluctant to attend the Skills Enhancement Lab for coaching?” Response options were “Definitely go!” and “Think about it...”

Question 2 (open-ended, optional): “This is optional. It would be appreciated if you would please explain your response to the first question.”

Analytic Approach

Quantitative analysis consisted of descriptive frequency tabulation for the forced-choice item. Qualitative analysis employed inductive thematic coding of the open-ended responses. Responses were read iteratively, initial codes were generated, and codes were grouped into candidate themes. Because responses frequently addressed multiple topics, each response was permitted to map to more than one theme. Word count statistics were computed to characterize response engagement.

Results

Forced-Choice Item

Of 68 respondents, 67 (98.5%) selected “Definitely go!” and 1 (1.5%) selected “Think about it...” The binary response format produces a pronounced ceiling effect with zero analyzable variance. While the near-unanimity constitutes a meaningful signal of student acceptance, the instrument does not permit statistical analysis of satisfaction gradients.

Open-Ended Responses

Response Rate and Characteristics

Sixty-two of 68 respondents (91.2%) provided written comments on the optional open-ended question. This voluntary response rate is notably high; typical optional survey response rates in educational research fall below 60%. The rate itself constitutes behavioral evidence of engagement—students who are indifferent do not write optional paragraphs. Response length ranged from 2 to 110 words ($M = 27.0$, $Mdn = 20$).

Thematic Analysis

Inductive thematic analysis of the 62 written responses identified eight themes. Table 1 presents the frequency and prevalence of each theme.

Table 1

Thematic Analysis of Open-Ended Responses (N = 62)

Theme	n	% of responses	Rank
<i>Specific skill practice and feedback</i>	43	69.4	1
<i>Named a specific coach positively</i>	24	38.7	2
<i>Anxiety/nervousness reduction</i>	21	33.9	3
<i>Hands-on/practice-based learning</i>	20	32.3	4
<i>Increased confidence/self-efficacy</i>	12	19.4	5
<i>Intent to return or recommend</i>	6	9.7	6
<i>1:1 personalized attention</i>	5	8.1	7
<i>Non-judgmental/safe environment</i>	3	4.8	8

Note. Responses could map to multiple themes; percentages sum to more than 100%.

Skill Practice and Feedback

The most prevalent theme (69.4%) reflected students' perception that the SEL provided concrete, actionable skill development opportunities. Respondents described receiving specific behavioral feedback on identifiable microskills and being able to implement corrections in real time during the session. This dominance is significant: the primary student experience was formative skill development, not generalized warmth or social support.

Named a Specific Coach Positively

Nearly four in ten respondents (38.7%) spontaneously named their coach by name in a positive context. This is behaviorally noteworthy: unprompted naming indicates a personal,

memorable interaction rather than a generic institutional experience. Named coaches included faculty members (Dr. Glavin, Dr. Boyd, Dr. Moore) and doctoral-level students (Abraham/Abe, Sharral Dean, Jessica, Ebony, Toni/Trevor, Ada, Peter, Bree Wilson, Tanisha, Keandra, Lynnetta, and Kay-Ann), suggesting consistent quality across coach types.

Anxiety and Nervousness Reduction

One third of respondents (33.9%) described entering the SEL with anxiety or nervousness and experiencing relief during or after the session. Combined with the 19.4% who reported increased confidence and self-efficacy, these data suggest the SEL is successfully lowering the affective barrier that impedes skill acquisition in novice counselors. This is particularly relevant in the fully online program context, where students have limited prior exposure to live skill performance and may encounter performance vulnerability for the first time during the SEL.

Hands-On, Practice-Based Learning

Respondents who described the value of experiential, applied learning (32.3%) distinguished the SEL from passive or didactic instruction. Several specifically noted the ability to pause, receive feedback, and immediately re-attempt the skill—a pattern consistent with the deliberate practice framework (Ericsson, 2008).

Confidence and Self-Efficacy

Approximately one in five respondents (19.4%) reported increased confidence in their counseling abilities. The language used aligns with Bandura's (1997) conceptualization of self-efficacy as domain-specific confidence in one's ability to perform a given task, suggesting the SEL may be activating mastery experience as a source of self-efficacy information.

Remaining Themes

Students who expressed intent to return or recommend the SEL (9.7%), noted the value of one-on-one personalized attention (8.1%), or explicitly named the non-judgmental/safe environment (4.8%) reinforced the overall pattern. The safety theme is likely underrepresented in the coding, as the quality of non-judgment permeated many responses coded under other themes but was only coded here when explicitly named.

The Single Non-Endorsing Respondent

The one respondent who selected “Think about it...” is arguably the most instructive data point. This individual’s open-ended response described initial reluctance and the process of overcoming it, concluding: “I’m glad I hit the join button.” This is not a dissatisfied participant; it is someone being honest about their pre-session hesitancy while still endorsing the experience. The cautious forced-choice selection reflects the affective starting point, not the outcome.

Discussion

Interpretation

Three quantitative indicators warrant emphasis. First, the 98.5% endorsement rate, while subject to ceiling effects, represents a level of student acceptance that is rare in voluntary educational interventions. Second, the 91.2% voluntary response rate on an optional open-ended question is itself a behavioral measure of engagement. Third, the mean response length of 27 words for an optional item indicates substantive engagement rather than perfunctory compliance.

The thematic structure of the qualitative data maps directly onto established constructs in counselor education and development. The dominance of skill practice and feedback (69.4%) aligns with the deliberate practice framework (Ericsson, 2008), which posits that expert performance develops through structured, repetitive practice with immediate expert feedback. The anxiety reduction theme (33.9%) reflects the well-documented phenomenon of performance

anxiety in novice counselors (Friedlander et al., 1986) and its reduction through supportive relational conditions (Stoltenberg & McNeill, 2010). The self-efficacy theme (19.4%) maps to Bandura's (1997) social cognitive theory, specifically the mechanism of mastery experience.

This convergence between naive student reports and established theory is methodologically significant. Students were not prompted with theoretical constructs; they independently described experiences that align with what the literature predicts should matter. This constitutes preliminary evidence that the SEL is activating the intended mechanisms of change.

The Significance of the Online Context

The fully online modality amplifies both the need for and the perceived value of the SEL. In face-to-face programs, students experience gradual habituation to clinical performance observation through repeated in-person interactions. Online students encounter this performance vulnerability abruptly, often for the first time during pre-practicum or practicum experiences. The SEL provides a structured, low-stakes environment for this critical developmental transition. CACREP (2024) Standard 1.N requires programs to demonstrate that instructional modality does not compromise clinical training quality. The SEL directly addresses this standard by providing a synchronous, individualized clinical training experience that would otherwise be absent from the online curriculum. For the population studied, the SEL is not a supplement to the curriculum; it is the only setting in which live, individualized skill practice with expert feedback occurs.

What the Data Do Not Support

The present data constitute a post-experience satisfaction survey with no pre-test, no control group, and no direct skill outcome measure. Causal claims that the SEL produced skill improvement cannot be supported from this data alone. What can be claimed is that students

perceive the SEL as valuable and that it reduces anxiety around skill practice. The 98.5% endorsement rate is compelling but reflects ceiling effects; there is zero variance to analyze statistically on the forced-choice item. A multi-point Likert scale (e.g., 1–7) would have provided measurable spread and permitted analysis of satisfaction predictors.

Limitations

Several limitations should be acknowledged. First, the post-only design precludes measurement of change; reported confidence increases and anxiety reductions reflect subjective perception, not documented pre-post shifts. Second, the binary forced-choice item creates a ceiling effect with no analyzable variance. Third, there is no control or comparison group; all respondents experienced the SEL, and without comparison to non-attendees, causal claims cannot be supported. Fourth, no direct skill outcome was measured; the data capture perceived value, not demonstrated competency. Fifth, the anonymous data collection prevents linkage to academic outcomes, retention data, repeat attendance patterns, or demographic characteristics. Sixth, as a voluntary intervention, students who chose to attend may differ systematically from those who did not, introducing selection bias. Seventh, findings reflect a single program, a single set of coaches, and a single student population, limiting generalizability.

Recommendations for Future Research

Three methodological enhancements would elevate these findings from program feedback to defensible program evaluation data:

1. **Add a pre-post measure of counseling self-efficacy.** Even a single-item confidence scale (e.g., 1–10) administered before and after the session would permit computation of change scores. A validated instrument such as the Counseling Activity Self-Efficacy

Scales (CASES; Lent et al., 2003) administered at the beginning and end of term would provide robust pre-post data.

2. **Replace the binary forced-choice item with a multi-point Likert scale.** A 7-point scale across multiple satisfaction dimensions would eliminate the ceiling effect and provide item-level variance for statistical analysis.
3. **Track repeat attendance and link to academic outcomes.** Shifting from anonymous to confidential data collection would permit dose-response analysis (number of sessions attended as a predictor of outcomes) and linkage to institutional variables including retention, course completion, and clinical placement readiness.

The qualitative data from Cycle 1 are genuinely strong. Students are articulating specific mechanisms of change—practice, feedback, anxiety reduction, non-judgment—rather than offering vague praise. This convergence with established theoretical constructs provides a solid foundation for a more rigorous Cycle 2 investigation employing validated instruments, pre-post measurement, and mixed-methods analysis.

Conclusion

The Cycle 1 data establish that the Skills Enhancement Lab is feasible, well-received, and perceived by students as producing specific, identifiable benefits aligned with established theoretical mechanisms in counselor education. Near-universal endorsement (98.5%), a high voluntary qualitative response rate (91.2%), and thematic convergence with constructs including deliberate practice, self-efficacy, anxiety reduction, and non-evaluative feedback conditions provide a strong empirical foundation for the continuation and expansion of the SEL, as well as for more rigorous investigation in subsequent research cycles.

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